

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience advising clients on family, housing, employment and welfare matters at Citizens Advice, and supporting complex litigation and disputes at BCLP. Experienced in managing cases from instruction to submission, taking client statements, drafting correspondence, preparing document schedules, maintaining confidential file records and meeting deadlines across competing matters. Comfortable handling sensitive client situations with clarity and care.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Covered international arbitration, dispute resolution procedure, evidence analysis and legal research
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy): 75%
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions

Law LLB — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme — Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Interviews clients across family, housing, welfare benefits, employment, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Manages matters from instruction to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Assesses eligibility for Universal Credit, Housing Benefit and related support against statutory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points
- Advises clients on procedural requirements and options, translating complex rules into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable individuals

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial
- Drafted procedural orders and procedural histories; amended sections of the Claimant's memorial; conducted legal research
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time submission
- Maintained structured electronic case files; monitored procedural deadlines; liaised with the client on required documents and coordinated external translations
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Supported hearing preparation: reviewed documents, prepared electronic bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Prepared client notes; maintained matter records via iManage; assisted with court filings and deadline tracking
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines

Q-Legal · London**Oct 2024 – Jan 2025****Legal Adviser**

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with client and supervising solicitor to meet deadline

Adobe · London**June 2022 – Aug 2022****Legal Intern**

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries; communicated amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; client interviewing and factual statement-taking; correspondence drafting; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; document review; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Case-file organisation, deadline tracking, hearing bundle preparation, document scheduling, procedural histories